

AFRICA, WEST



THE ATLANTIC OCEAN borders all but three of the 15 countries that make up West Africa. Much of the area is dominated by the Sahara and the Sahel, a vast area of semi-desert, which the Sahara is slowly invading. Despite their potential wealth and rich resources, most of the countries are desperately poor. Long-established trade routes across the Sahara link West Africa with the Mediterranean coast to the north. For millions of West Africans, life is a perpetual struggle against a hostile climate, the threat of drought, and political instability.

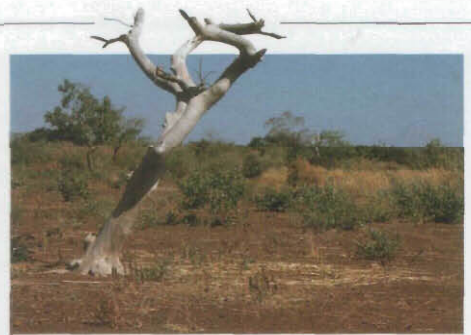
Physical features

Most of West Africa lies 200–400 m (600–1200 ft) above sea-level. The Sahara dominates Niger, Mauritania, and Mali, and the Sahel extends south into Senegal, Burkina Faso, and Nigeria. The rivers Senegal, Gambia, Volta, and Niger irrigate the west and south.



River Niger

Africa's third longest river, the Niger flows in a great arc for 4,180 km (2,597 miles) from Guinea through Mali, Niger, Benin, and Nigeria to a vast delta on the Gulf of Guinea. A valuable source of fish and water, it is navigable for more than half its length.

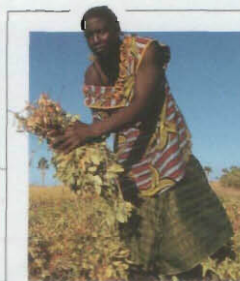


Sahel

Immediately south of the Sahara Desert, stretching all the way across West Africa, is a broad band of hot, arid, semi-desert grassland called the Sahel. In Arabic, the word Sahel means "shore" of the desert. Rainfall in this region is sporadic and droughts are common.

Regional climate

Moving from north to south, there are four main climate regions in West Africa: desert, Sahel, grassland, and tropical rainforest. Rain is rare in the northern desert and Sahel regions, yet the south is humid and tropical with a distinct rainy season that can last for four to six months.



Harvesting peanuts

Groundnuts

Also called peanuts, groundnuts develop underground. They are widely grown in West Africa as a source of edible oil, and as a foodstuff that is rich in protein and vitamins. The plants were introduced into West Africa from South America.

